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From *Ground Zero* (2024) and *A Fidai Film* (2024): Archival Activism in Palestinian Cinema in Times of Genocide

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ABSTRACT

The first globally live-streamed genocide has intensified the dichotomous visual regime that has been framing Palestine as either invisible or hypervisible over seventy-seven years of *al-Nakba al-mustamirra* (“the ongoing catastrophe”). Within this saturated yet obscured mediascape, the paper explores how contemporary Palestinian cinema mobilizes visual archives as sites of dissensus (Stoler 2018), reclaiming both creative and narrative agency. Grounded in Palestinian cultural studies and critical archival theory, I analyze Rashid Masharawi’s *From Ground Zero* and Kamal Aljafari’s *A Fidai Film* – both released after October 2023 – to articulate what I term “archival activism”, a fusion of activism and archival engagement crystallizing into two tendencies. Masharawi’s filmic anthology embodies what I call “Gaze on Gaza,” a cinematic practice generating synchronous counter-archives in times of genocide. Aljafari’s film, by contrast, exemplifies the *dispositif* of the «camera of the dispossessed», deploying radically imaginative and often opaque (Glissant 1990) reuse of found footage as a decolonial practice. Through close filmic reading of the two case studies, I foreground contemporary cinematic modes that position the archive as a resistant tool of countervisuality (Mirzoeff 2011), thereby expanding debates on the insurgent potential of archival imagination under settler-colonial violence, and framing cinema as a site where memory, resistance, and futurity converge.

KEYWORDS

Archival Activism / Palestinian Cinema / Countervisuality / Memoricide / Fabulation

1 - Introduction

The systemic destruction of most archives in Gaza¹ is only the visible layer of a deeper architecture of settler-colonial violence shaping Palestine since 1948, widely referred to as *al-Nakba al-mustamirra* (“the ongoing catastrophe”). Palestinian history has

¹ For an extensive – though not exhaustive – account of the physical destruction of archives during the Gaza genocide, see Ghaddar 2025.

been repeatedly marked by programmatic annihilation enacted through intertwined practices of de-Arabization and displacement. Together, these constitute what Beshara Doumani describes as the «erasure of the two greatest archives of all: the physical landscape, and the bonds of daily life that constitute an organic social formation» (2009:4). Within the broader framework of epistemicide,² Israeli historian Ilan Pappé identifies this dynamic as «memoricide» (2007), that is, the deliberate attempt to silence historical memory through the systematic targeting of archives, libraries, and repositories of knowledge, in order to legitimize Zionist occupation.

Visuality sits at the center of the erasure project, since the colonial «will to rubble» (Abourahme 2024:15) has historically positioned Palestine within a conflicted visual paradigm oscillating between visibility and invisibility.³ It is within this dialectic tension that Edward Said, in his introduction to one of the milestone volumes on Palestinian cinema, frames Palestinian films as «a visual alternative, a visible incarnation of Palestinian existence, [...] a way of resisting an imposed identity [...] by articulating a counter-narrative and a counter-identity» (Dabashi 2006:3). Said's reflections resonate even more forcefully within the saturated yet obscured mediascape inaugurated by the Gaza genocide, which I describe as a necrovisual regime, where «the production of images that glorify violence operates as a form of social control that normalizes violence» (Valencia & Sepúlveda 2016:84).⁴ Against this backdrop, the article focuses on visual archives and the critical strategies through which contemporary Palestinian filmmakers reappropriate archival agency in times of genocide. I refer to the set of these decolonial practices as “archival activism”, a toolbox merging artistic forms with political intents.

At the center of my analysis are two post-October 2023 Palestinian films: *From Ground Zero* (2024) by Rashid Masharawi [Rašīd Mašharāwī] and *A Fidai Film* (2024) by

² The Latin-derived suffix *-cide* has generated a hypertrophic yet paradoxically inadequate vocabulary for describing forms of Zionist annihilation. Among the terms emerging in Palestinian studies there are: *spaciocide* (Hanafi 2009), referring to the destruction of Palestinian living space; *urbicide* (Graham 2004), denoting the emptying, demolition, and colonization of urban environments; and *scholasticide* (Nabulsi 2009), describing the systematic dismantling of educational institutions.

³ In the introduction to *Palestinian Cinema in the Days of Revolution*, Nadia Yaqub argues that hypervisibility began in the late 1960s, when some organized armed resistance movements adopted practices of «propaganda of the deed» (2018:3). This facilitated their association with terrorism, giving rise to what Collins has termed the «Palestinian's curse of visibility» (2011:6), meaning that Palestinian visibility has been largely controlled by others, remaining invisible until its violence becomes too visible.

⁴ I use the term «necrovisuality» coined by Valencia and Sepúlveda as a visual mechanism of capitalism, because it proves particularly apt within the Palestinian context, especially after October 2023: a regime that oscillates between invisibilizing and hyper-exposing bodies, calibrating white sight to dull outrage and depoliticize humanitarian perception.

Kamal Aljafari [Kamāl al-ḡaʿfarī], which illuminate a wide range of forms and genres. *From Ground Zero* is a collective feature composed of twenty-two short fictional and non-fictional films shot in the Gaza Strip between January and May 2024, staging the intimacy of daily life amid systematic annihilation – a vivid example of counter-archiving from within. *A Fidai Film*, by contrast, is an experimental feature-length documentary that reworks dispossessed archival materials. Though conceived before October 2023, its release and reception unfolded within the current mediascape of the Gaza genocide, situating its poetics of reappropriation inside the very visual regime it contests.

Scholarship on Palestinian cultural practices increasingly turns to the archive as a contested site where power, colonial violence, and visibility are negotiated (Appadurai 2003; Doumani 2009; Azoulay 2019; Stoler 2021). Palestinian film studies likewise examine how cinematic production engages these dynamics, shaping national imaginaries and generating counter-narratives (Dabashi 2006; Gertz & Khleifi 2008; Yaqoub 2018, 2023; Burris 2020; Habashneh 2023). Building on this body of work, I draw on scholars who develop analyses of visual agency through radical imaginative practices used in Palestinian cinema to re-envision archival absence and colonial oblivion (Hochberg 2021; Estefan 2022). This article intervenes in current debates by examining two recent films that have received little scholarly attention, despite their significance within ongoing discussions on Palestinian visuality.

Ultimately, as a non-Palestinian scholar, I approach this work with an awareness of my own positionality and of the risk of reproducing what Nicholas Mirzoeff terms «white sight» (2023): the epistemic frame structuring the colonial gaze even within sympathetic critique. My aim is therefore not to speak on behalf of Palestinian filmmakers but to amplify the trajectories of those who are reconfiguring the visual field from within. My curatorial work for the Nazra Palestine Short Film Festival, including an itinerant seminar series on visual archives that I curated as scientific director,⁵ informs this study too, grounding it in an ongoing dialogue with key figures of contemporary Palestinian cinema and scholarship.

2 - Archival Artivism in Palestinian contemporary cinema: fabulation, parafiction, and the right to opacity

What is no longer archived in the same way is no longer lived in the same way
(Derrida 1995:18)

Taking Derrida's insight as a point of departure, this paper conceptualizes archival activism as both an artistic practice and a political intervention. It is situated within

⁵ *Memory as Resistance*, October 15-24, 2025: <https://pdflink.to/53eda354/>.

the field of critical archival thinking, aligning with scholarly traditions that approach the archive not as a neutral repository of past truths, but as a site of dissensus (Stoler 2018), where memories and counter-narratives are negotiated with renewed political force. My analysis draws on Sonia Hegasy's notion of archival activism (2019), understood as a constellation of grassroots and interdisciplinary practices that mobilize creative and political strategies to counter-archive dominant narratives. I place this in dialogue with the concept of activism, as articulated by Gielen and De Bruyne (2012) and by Duncombe and Lambert (2018), where artistic practice operates as a form of critical agency mediating between radical creativity and political efficacy.

Building on these contributions, I adopt archival activism as a methodological toolbox for examining the productive tension between the aesthetic and the socio-political functions in films that engage the archive. Following the work of Gil Hochberg (2021) and Kareem Estefan (2022), I read contemporary Palestinian cinema through the concept of archival imagination, understood as «imagining existing archives differently as well as creating new archival effects and affects [...] often mobilized by archival fever» (Hochberg 2021:16).

Central to this framework is Saidiya Hartman's concept of critical fabulation (2008), originally formulated within Black Studies as a decolonial method that enables Afro-American women to engage creatively with the colonial Atlantic archive without reproducing its epistemic violence. Fabulation re-emerges in Estefan's words as «an act of radical narrative imagination that animates unrealized political potential glimpsed in the gaps of archives subjected to colonial violations» (Estefan 2022:31). In this sense, it reclaims agency for subjects historically reduced to archival objects, unsettling the idea that archives are mere portals to the past and recasting them as spaces for deconstruction, speculation, and imagining otherwise.

Cinematic storytelling engaging memory and archives thus shifts from a forensic pursuit of historical truth toward a generative engagement with Palestinian futurity, shaping potential imaginaries. One of the key modes through which fabulation unfolds is parafiction, an artistic practice theorized by Carrie Lambert-Beatty in her seminal essay *Make-Believe: Parafiction and Plausibility* (2009). It designates hybrid aesthetic forms in which fact and fiction intertwine so thoroughly that they become difficult to disentangle, a liminal mode in which veracity is continually negotiated rather than assumed. This mode responds to the urgent need to resist the fictive realities embedded in colonial archives and normalized as historical truth. When applied to cinema, parafiction destabilizes conventional genre boundaries and constructs new narrative worlds from the very voids produced by colonial violence. Fiction, in this context, is not an alternative to truth but one of its epistemological tools, which inhabits archival absence by shaping decolonial narratives.

Traditional dichotomies such as fiction/history, past/future, testimony/aspiration

are dissolved within archival activism as practices of countervisuality, what Mirzoeff describes as «a dissensus with visibility» (2011:24), calling for a necessary rearrangement of the visual field. The dominant necrovisual paradigm, shaped by quantitative narratives that normalize colonial violence through the overexposure of Palestinian bodies as either survivors or corpses, must be countered by resisting its very visual codes. This process entails a withdrawal from the aesthetic forms through which the colonial white gaze is produced, corresponding to what Édouard Glissant theorized as the right to opacity: a refusal «to be made visible through the colonial, heteropatriarchal, white gaze» (Mirzoeff 2011:6). Opacity does not denote obscurity but a form of non-immediate legibility that affirms the right of oppressed subjects to see and be seen in modes partially resistant to capture, opening alternative ways of sensing and envisioning Palestine and its people. The right to opacity materializes through several deconstructive tactics that unsettle the viewer beyond the parameters of colonial narrative and visibility. Among them is what Estefan calls a «reorientation of temporality» (2022:32), the disruption of the teleological historical order typical of imperialist chronologies.

With this methodological lens, I analyze my two case studies through a close filmic reading across visual and sonic registers to examine the tactics through which «the manipulation, reproduction, and often experimental and playful alteration of pre-given state and personal archives» (Hochberg 2021:15) unfold at both formal and thematic levels.

3 - Palestinian revolutionary cinema and its archive: self-representation and colonial violation

As this paper centers on Palestinian visibility and the urgent need to reactivate dispossessed visual archives, this section traces the formation, consolidation, and violent dispersal of the Palestinian film archive, culminating in its looting during the Israeli siege of Beirut in 1982.⁶ Any discussion of Palestinian visual archives must begin with the earliest attempts at cinematic self-representation and, by extension, with the experiences of the so-called «knights of cinema», borrowing the title of the recent volume by Khadijeh Habashneh [Ḥadiġa Ḥabašna] (2023). One of the first Palestinian filmmakers, archivists, and women's rights activists working under occupation, Habashneh reconstructs in her book the trajectory of the Palestine Film Unit (PFU), whose emergence marks a turning point in the history of Palestinian visual agency.

⁶ In June 1982, the destruction of PLO research centre in Beirut occurred during the Lebanese Civil War (1975–1990), when Israeli forces besieged the city for two months, forcing the PLO's evacuation to Tunisia and leaving Palestinian civilians exposed to atrocities, most notoriously the massacres at Sabra and Shatila.



Figure 1 - Poster from 1988 by SAMED, the Economic Affairs Institute of the PLO. Artworks by Abdel Rahman Al Muzain. Courtesy of Khadijah Habashneh. The translation of the Arabic writings is: «Palestinian cinema is a testimony of the past, the vitality of the present, and the brilliance of the future»

Early experiments in Palestinian filmmaking can be traced back to the British Mandate period, with Ibrahim Hassan Sirhan [Ibrāhīm Ḥasan Sarḥān]’s documentaries and the founding of *Studio Palestine* in Ramallah in 1945 (Gertz & Khleifi 2008:12). Yet the massive dispossession wrought by the Nakba erased nearly all traces of this pioneering practice. What would later become the Palestinian film archive thus emerged not in historic Palestine but in exile, more than two decades later. However, its genesis is primarily tied to the experiences of three photographers later turned to filmmakers – Sulafa Jadallah [Sulāfa Ġād Allāh], Hani Jawhariyyeh [Hānī Ġawhariyya], and Mustafa Abu Ali [Muṣṭafā Abū ‘Alī]– who began crafting a counter-image to dominant Zionist narratives from the kitchen of a small apartment in Amman, founding the PFU.

After Black September in 1970,⁷ the Unit relocated to Beirut and was reconstituted

⁷ Black September refers to the Jordanian army’s brutal crackdown on the PLO and Palestinian refugee camps around Amman in 1970, resulting in the forced displacement of thousands.

as the Palestinian Cinema Institute (PCI). While these groups operated within the institutional orbit of Fatah [Fataḥ],⁸ Palestinian countervisual practices quickly expanded across other branches of the Palestinian Liberation Organization (PLO), notably the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), and the Democratic Front for the Liberation of Palestine (DFLP).

Palestinian Revolutionary cinema developed a distinct militant cinematic language. Too often dismissed reductively as propaganda, the films shot by its directors embodied the tension between artistic form and revolutionary urgency that underpinned debates within the cultural arm of the PLO. Short documentaries became the emblematic form of Palestinian early cinema, yet filmmakers such as Abu Ali remained in constant pursuit of formal experimentation, developing new visual grammars even in a context where political imperatives often overshadowed aesthetic innovation. Palestinian filmmaking soon became a beacon of Third World cinema,⁹ circulating through international festivals and solidarity circuits, and attracting global allies who traveled to the region to film in support of the struggle – among them, Jean-Luc Godard, whose documentary *Ici et ailleurs* (1976) remains a key testament to these transnational collaborations.

As the networks of revolutionary cinema expanded, the need for a systematic archival structure became increasingly urgent. In 1974, the Palestinian Cinema Archive was formally established in Beirut, and by 1976 it contained around ninety works (Habashneh 2023:106), managed by Habashneh herself. The collection included films from Global South solidarity movements and original reels shot in refugee camps, training bases, and battlefields, used by both Palestinian and international filmmakers. These materials constituted the most extensive attempt at building a Palestinian visual memory to date, indeed the first national Palestinian visual archive ever assembled.

In August 1982, all this material, together with other «historical archives and a 25,000-volume library and microfilm collection were looted and carted away by the Israeli army» during the siege of Beirut (Chomsky 1999:422). The Palestine Research Centre was destroyed, and with it, decades of footage produced at great human cost were obliterated. Hundreds of reels were taken to Israel, where they remain under mi-

⁸ Fatah, an acronym formed by inverting the Arabic name *Ḥaraka(t) al-Taḥrīr al-Filasṭīnī* (Palestinian Liberation Movement), is the largest organization within the confederated, multi-party Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO). Founded in 1959 by members of the Palestinian diaspora—most notably Yasser Arafat – it emerged as a central political and military actor in the modern Palestinian national movement.

⁹ Third World cinema emerged across Africa, Asia, and Latin America in the 1960s and 70s as a transnational movement fusing anti-imperialist politics with aesthetic experimentation. It sought to challenge Euro-American cinematic dominance and to articulate decolonial narratives from the global South.

litary custody.¹⁰ This was one of the largest single acts of cultural plunder in the history of modern Palestine. Crucially, 1982 marks not only a geopolitical rupture but also a decisive turning point in the history of Palestinian cinema: a moment in which a collective visual memory was fragmented, displaced, and folded into the archival logic of the colonizer.

The practices of memoricide and archival erasure masterfully chronicled by Nur Masalha (2012) intensified the so-called Palestinian «archival fever» (Doumani 2008: 6) that unfolded simultaneously on material and immaterial levels. The search for the stolen archive mobilized a transnational constellation of filmmakers, scholars, and visual activists, with Habashneh herself playing a central role. Beginning in 2006, she and her former husband, Abu Ali, began locating fragments of the lost archive scattered across international institutions, often supported by Third Cinema allies (Habashneh 2023:135). At the same time, additional reels resurfaced unexpectedly in remote locations through private collections, diplomatic donations, and long-forgotten solidarity networks, attesting to the tenacity of archival traces.

One of the most emblematic examples is the rediscovery of a twenty-film collection preserved for decades in a Japanese private archive, a legacy from a Japanese solidarity group supporting the Palestinian struggle. Known as the Tokyo Reels, these films came to light after screenings of Mohanad Yaqubi [Muhannad Ya‘qūbī]’s *Off Frame AKA Revolution Until Victory* (2016), a work that reflects on militant filmmakers’ efforts to reclaim image and narrative agency. The restoration of the Tokyo Reels later culminated in Yaqubi’s second feature, *R21 AKA Restoring Solidarity* (2022), where “R21” symbolically designates the twenty-first reel added to the collection, reframing archival loss as a site of renewed transnational solidarity. Equally significant is the work of Monica Maurer,¹¹ who, together with visual artist Emily Jacir [ʿAmalī Ġāsir], rediscovered and digitized the reels of the landmark documentary *Tall Al-Zaatar* (Abu Ali, Adriano, Chamoun 1977), which had been stored in a warehouse of the Italian Audiovisual Archive of the Democratic Workers’ Movement (AAMOD) in Rome for nearly forty years.

Yet despite these efforts, Habashneh insists that «the archive is lost, and the process of looking for it is impeded» (2023:142), meaning not only that scattered fragments cannot constitute an archive in the absence of missing materials and the classificatory

¹⁰ The fate of the Palestinian film archive remained shrouded in uncertainty for decades. In 2017, Israeli researcher Rona Sela published an article – later expanded into a book and a film – revealing that the stolen materials were held in Israeli military archives. BDS advocates, notably filmmaker and scholar Eyal Sivan, criticized Sela’s intervention as a typical act of liberal Zionist appropriation: publicly calling for restitution while materially obstructing it and building academic careers on looted Palestinian archives. (Online interview with Eyal Sivan, 17 April, 2025).

¹¹ Monica Maurer is a German filmmaker who played an active role in Palestinian revolutionary cinema and currently serves on the board of AAMOD.

principles that once structured it, but also that the impediment is intentional rather than accidental. It reflects what Ghaddar defines as archival apartheid (2025:5): the systematic exclusion of Palestinians from accessing their own archives and, by extension, the structural impossibility of archiving under colonial rule. This condition resonates directly with the visual strategies examined in this paper.

4 - Gaze on Gaza: counter-archiving from within in *From Ground Zero*

The phrase “Gaze on Gaza” originated from a pun linking the English translation of *naẓra* (“gaze”) with the toponym of the Strip. I first coined it as the title of a Palestinian film showcase organized in Turin in collaboration with the Nazra Palestine Short Film Festival in November 2023, at the outset of the genocide. It later became an official competition section in the 2024 edition of the festival, dedicated to short films created inside the Strip during the Gaza genocide. Regardless of genre, the defining criterion for inclusion is Palestinian authorship, positioning the category as a visual counter-archive of the present catastrophe. In this analysis, I extend the term to describe the toolbox of archival activism enacted in *From Ground Zero*.

The film’s original Arabic title, *Min al-masāfa ṣifr* – literally “From Zero Distance” or “At Close Range” – conveys its agential perspective, made even more explicit by the intertitle of the opening short *Selfies*. With cameras pointed at their own bodies, gestures, and surroundings, Gazan filmmakers recount the genocide from within, framing life under conditions defined by systemic death. Through the support of the *Masharawi Fund for Films and Filmmakers in Gaza* established in late 2023 by self-taught Gazan director Rashid Masharawi,¹² people enduring genocide are empowered to represent themselves through their own gaze, interrupting the dominant necrovisual paradigm. The filmic anthology unfolds through a parafictional aesthetic that unsettles the colonial conventions typically used to frame Gaza, rejecting both reportage and conventional documentary form. Fiction, animation, documentary, experimental film, and video art coexist in the collection, while news footage and quantitative narratives are deliberately absent. As artistic consultant and former PLO filmmaker Layal Badr [Liyāl Badr] noted during the film’s presentation at Torino Film Festival 2024, these works articulate «no political agenda»,¹³ meaning that no external geopolitical gaze structures the narration. The absence of international intervention to prevent or stop the genocide translates cinematically into a refusal to reproduce the visual grammar of war.

Within this framework, irony – long a hallmark of Palestinian cinema – becomes

¹² Through on-site production teams, remote mentoring, and transnational post-production, the project transformed filmmakers into both storytellers and the story itself, sublimating their colonial visual position as objects into subjects of representation.

¹³ <https://shorturl.at/OjOKQ>. Last accessed November 29, 2025.

a key tactic of counter-archiving through fabulation, creatively subverting necrovisual tropes while reframing them as symbols of *ṣumūd*, creative resilience. *Hell's Heaven* offers a paradigmatic example, transforming the shroud – one of the most prominent visual tropes of genocide – into a grotesque shelter, a reclaimed space for a warm refuge for the living. A similar logic of ironic subversion animates *Awakening*, where director Mahdi Kreirah [Mahdi Karīra] crafts puppets from empty food cans, converting the necrovisual trope of famine into animated characters. These puppets recount the story of a patriarch who loses his memory during the 2014 war and paradoxically regains it after a new bombing, a darkly comic metaphor for the cyclical erasures of settler-colonial violence, staging genocide as part of a longer colonial continuum.



Figure 2 - Still from *Hell's Heaven* (Karim Satoum). The protagonist wakes up wrapped in a shroud, without remembering how. Courtesy of Revolver Film



Figure 3 - Still from *Awakening* (Mahdi Kreirah). A family scene from an ordinary day inside the tent. Courtesy of Revolver Film

The creative balancing between reality and fiction also frames the representation of «scholasticide» (Nabulsi 2009). Rather than depicting the rubble of destroyed schools and universities, the films deploy a visual logic of absence: in *The Teacher*, the protagonist roams Gaza not to teach but to scavenge food for his students, returning to his tent with empty jars; in *A School Day*, a child prepares his backpack only to visit his teacher's flowered grave; in *Out of Frame*, a young woman proudly presents her application project for a university that no longer exists – like all universities in the Strip.

The right to opacity, therefore, is not achieved by concealing genocide's symbols but by relegating them to the margins. Death, rubble, and tents remain in the background, while daily gestures and aspirations occupy the foreground through the device of fabulation. Oscillating between pessimism and optimism, parafiction offers a means to counter-archive even the most unbearable yet necessary practices. A striking example is the animated short *Soft Skin*, which stages the chilling act of Gazan mothers writing their children's names on different parts of their bodies (*ismī 'alā ġismī*) to ensure identification after potential bombings. Here, the “truth of fiction” emerges through the liminal aesthetics of the animation, which reframes the practice of infanticide as a site of collective meaning-making, considering that the short was created in a stop-motion workshop by children themselves who chose to fabulate this practice, thereby powerfully enacting archival agency.



Figure 4 - Still from *Soft Skin* (Khamis Masharawi). The practice of *ismī 'alā ġismī*. Courtesy of Revolver Film



Figure 5 - Still from *Soft Skin* (Khamis Masharawi). Stop-motion animation created by children. Courtesy of Revolver Film

Hochberg's insight that art «creates possible universes that escape the limits of history» (2021:8), permeates the narrative fabric of the anthology, where fiction and documentary continually merge. In *Overburden*, the pages of Radwa Ashour [Raḍwā 'Āšūr]'s *Woman of Tantoura* (2010) come to life through the character of 'Alā', whose forced exodus mirrors that of *Ruqayya*, the novel's *bint al-baḥr* ("daughter of the sea"). Typical colonial aerial shots – often instruments of dehumanizing white voyeurism – are replaced by eye-level framings which, together with the literary resonances, restore dignity and reframe the intimate trauma of displacement within collective memory. The shorts *Dance* and *Charm* depict teenage dance as a daily escape from war. In *Dance*, the protagonist's solitary dance to music in her headphones becomes a moment of private relief amid occupation. In *Charm*, individual sorrow transforms into a collective choreography of Palestinian folk dance *dabkeh*, overlaid with dreamlike *ṭaṭrīz* embroidery that visually contrasts with improvised clothing worn under siege. Visual art also takes center stage, as in the video-art short *Fragments*, where Basel al-Maqousi [Bāsil al-Maqūsī]'s black-and-white drawings rupture into red, depicting the intrusion of violence upon art and intimacy, and in *Out of Frame*, where a young woman sculpts with shards of bombed glass, turning debris into artworks. Finally, in *Everything Is Fine*, performance art surfaces as a comedian rehearses among ruins for a show in Nuseirat camp, only to find the camp destroyed upon arrival.

Above all, cinema becomes both medium and subject. In *Sorry Cinema*, director Ahmed Hassouna [ʿAḥmad Ḥassūna] – the only participant with prior filmmaking ex-

perience (*Istrupya*, 2019) – turns his initial reluctance to join the project into an elegy for the art he can no longer practice. The film ends with a striking shot: a shattered clapperboard burned to cook for his children. Art is sacrificed to sustain life; yet by staging this sacrifice, the film reclaims archival agency through fabulation in a powerful, desperate gesture.



Figure 6 - Still from *Sorry Cinema* (Ahmed Hassouna). The protagonist breaks his clapperboard to use it as firewood in the absence of gas. Courtesy of Revolver Film

From Ground Zero is a polyphonic feature of intimate yet universal experiences under siege, where fragmentation becomes ontological and thus the film's stylistic signature. The shorts' three-to-six-minute durations reflect not only the material constraints of filmmaking amid systemic scarcity, but also the fractured temporalities of life in Gaza and the scattered memories of Palestinian colonial history. The narration is punctuated by interruptions, both diegetic and extradiegetic. *Taxi Wanissa* offers the starkest example, in which director Etimad Washah [I'timād Waṣāḥ] interrupts her own film to inform viewers that her brother's family has been killed, making it impossible to continue filming. Reality enters the frame, revealing the anthology as a living archive shaped by the catastrophe it attempts to narrate.

Even the ordering of the shorts reflects a deliberate withdrawal from linear sequencing, resonating with the parafictional forms that resemanticize past, present, and future within the space of the plausible. Archival imagination here generates a new archive: «an archive of/for the future» (Hochberg 2021:2) in which hybrid forms reconfigure the temporal and affective grammar of witnessing as speculative intervention. The alteration of linear temporalities becomes visible in *Offerings*, where the protagonist describes the liminal temporality as *zaman ṭānī* ("another time"), a dimension in which

day and night collapse into one another. The intimate time of the short echoes a collective scene of tents, firewood, children, and song, where storytelling about the life of *ḡaddī Ḥālīd* shifts between the genocide and the first displacement from Jaffa to Gaza, binding 1948 dispossession to the present within the colonial continuum of *al-nakba al-mustamirra*. The motif of *zaman t̄ānī* resurfaces through fabulation in *Hell's Heaven*, where a young boy marks time in Rafah camp with a makeshift drum kit: a basin as bass drum, tin cans as percussion, and a cast-iron plate as cymbal, becoming an audiovisual trope of creativity amid destruction.



Figure 7 - Still from *Hell's Heaven* (Karim Satoum). A child plays a makeshift drum set in the Rafah tent camp.

Despite its endemic fragmentation, the feature resolves cinematically into a cohesive mosaic, tied together by recurring motifs across visual and sonic registers, which outline the contours of a broader Gazan counter-archive of the genocide. Audiovisual tropes of genocide intertwine with elements typical of Gazan visuality.¹⁴ At the intersection of sonic and visual registers stands the sea, Gaza's most enduring visual trope and its only border that cannot be altered, despite Israeli blockade. Its sound precedes its image in the first frames of *Selfies*, and recurs across the anthology – both as image and sound – serving as a connective tissue. The brief opening and closing titles of each

¹⁴ *Gaza on Screen* (2023) maps diverse visual tropes characteristic of films from and about Gaza, in contrast to those typical of the cinema of other area of historic Palestine. While checkpoints are a constant feature of West Bank cinema and of films set in the territories of 1948, they are almost entirely absent from Gazan filmmaking, where the dominant tropes are the sea and the drones.

film¹⁵ carry fragments of sound drawn from its interior scenes, producing a subtle sense of continuity across otherwise disconnected narratives.

On the sonic register, the most pervasive motif is Gaza's most distinct acoustic signature: *zannāna*, the onomatopoeic slang for Israeli drones. Although drones never appear in the shorts, they saturate the entire soundscape. In some cases, their noise was so intrusive that the filmmakers had to record voice-overs in makeshift production tents, adjusting sound in post-production. Yet the final films preserve the oppressive drone noise, maintaining the acoustic texture of occupation that has shaped daily life in Gaza since 2006, and even more intensely since October 2023.

If the right to opacity unfolds through non-linear temporality that disrupts positivist chronology while interrupting the necrovisual spectacle of power, the adherence of the soundscape to the visual plane reflects a deliberately legible mode of archival imagination. Against the obscurantism of Western media and the flattening narratives of the white sight, "Gaze on Gaza" counter-archives withdraws from visual conventions while remaining thematically transparent. Through the artifice of fabulation, the parafictional shorts of *From Ground Zero* repopulate Gaza with life, creativity, and possibility beyond the urgencies of survival. The camera lingers on ordinary objects – sometimes banal – that, under the epistemic conditions of genocide, acquire layered meaning: such as the bottle cast into the sea at the end of *Selfies*, a conventional trope of white visibility that becomes newly charged in a context where the sea itself can be understood as another wall of the settler-colonial prison.

From Ground Zero thus constitutes a synchronous counterarchive of the genocide, placing Palestinians at the center of narration as active political and creative agents. Despite the different historical conditions, the work of its amateur filmmakers resonates with the pioneering practices of the PLO's first filmmaking: both constitute acts of reclaiming archival agency, moving from being objects to the very subjects of visibility. If earlier PLO cinema transforms the figure of Palestinians from refugees into freedom fighters, the "Gaze on Gaza" filmmakers extend this legacy by transforming themselves from survivors into creators, while exercising their «right to look» (Mirzoeff 2011) and to be seen otherwise.

5 - The Camera of the Dispossessed: reappropriating found footage in *A Fidai Film*

Drawing from a diegetic reference to Aljafari's filmography, I use the concept of the "camera of dispossessed" to name the set of radical imaginative practices mobilized

¹⁵ The minimal textual material in the opening and closing credits reflects the limited resources under which these shorts were produced. The same names often recur across different films, taking on multiple roles from one short to the next.

in *A Fidai Film*. Emerging from the lineage of the so-called «Jaffa trilogy» (Hochberg 2021:54) and refined in Aljafari's installation for the 35th São Paulo Biennial, the “camera of the dispossessed” becomes, in this film, both a methodological *dispositif* and the title of one of its internal chapters. It designates a mode of seeing in which the camera is never neutral, and becomes a creative tool of archival imagination that confronts found footage not as mere audiovisual records but as contested sites of power, violence, and reappropriation.

The film's title further tightens this articulation between visibility, resistance and agency. Aljafari invokes the original Arabic meaning of *fidā'ī*,¹⁶ literally “one who sacrifices himself,” hence “freedom fighter”, while subverting its Hebrew resemanticization, in which the same term is reframed as “saboteur.” The film inhabits both meanings and turns their tension into a method. It acts as a freedom fighter insofar as it struggles to liberate seized images and stolen histories, yet it also acts as a saboteur of visual regimes, infiltrating and derailing the very archives and cinematic grammars that have sustained colonial storytelling. In this sense, *A Fidai Film* is not simply about liberation: it is itself an act of liberation, through radical experimentality and fabulation.

This double movement binds the film to the early practices of PFU and PCI. Both the first generations of PLO filmmakers and Aljafari operated outside historic Palestine,¹⁷ yet the connection is even more literal in the nature of the materials themselves. Much of the footage Aljafari appropriates derives directly from the 1982 looted PLO archive, alongside Israeli fictional cinema available in open-access during the saturated mediascape of the global pandemic, and which he appropriated by circumventing anti-piracy restrictions.¹⁸ The heterogeneity of these sources converges within what Nadia Yaqub terms «hostile archives» (2025): the archives of the oppressor and of global institutions created to stymie rather than further Palestinian liberation. These include Mandate-era reels, Israeli state collections, and materials looted from Palestinian private and institutional archives, later reclassified within the Zionist archival order. Working with these images, Aljafari enacts what Estefan terms «the right to fabulation» (2022:61), generating a countervisuality that exceeds the narrow thresholds of documentary proof.

The 1982 Israeli attack on the Palestine Research Center in Ras Beirut becomes the film's narrative and theoretical hinge. *A Fidai Film* returns to this event three times, staging it from different perspectives. The first iteration addresses the Palestinians' point of view, rendered through near-minimal sound, as if the thunder of bombardment had

¹⁶ *Fidā'ī* being the singular of *fidā'iyyūn*, more commonly known in its simplified translation as *fedayeen*.

¹⁷ Aljafari is a Palestinian director of the diaspora who trained and worked for many years in Germany, earning critical acclaim before leaving the country following the onset of the Gaza genocide and escalating political pressures against Palestinians.

¹⁸ Online interview with Aljafari, 20 January, 2025.

collapsed into epistemic silence. Smoke, debris, and bodies in frantic motion fill the screen. Rather than providing informational clarity, the scene conveys disorientation, mirroring the shattering of an entire archival infrastructure. Here silence is not absence but an index of what cannot be captured yet insists on being felt. The second iteration shifts focus to the Israeli army. Two officers, speaking in Hebrew, move through the damaged building: one rummaging proudly through archival shelves, the other loading boxes onto tanks destined for Israel. This sequence visually condenses archival apartheid, enacted here as a concrete military operation involving the seizure, removal, and relocation of an entire visual memory from Beirut to the heart of the colonial entity. Aljafari offers no commentary and lets the choreography of the soldiers articulate the violence of colonial uprooting and reclassification.



Figure 8 - Still from A Fidai Film. An Israeli officer announces that the materials will be taken to Israel for surveillance analysis. Courtesy of Kamal Aljafari Productions

Finally, the third iteration is mediated by a British journalist reporting in English before the ruins. His presence translates devastation into the grammar of Western news, externalizing what had been intimate catastrophe. By repeating the same event with three different focalizations, *A Fidai Film* enacts the right to opacity through a parafictional aesthetic that unsettles teleological notions of historical sequencing. The event is historical and verifiable, yet its representation remains unstable, circulating among registers without ever being fully captured by one and inviting the viewer to inhabit the gaps and blind spots of archival violence beyond linear logic.

Repetition and interruption must be read within the broader framework of deli-

berate fragmentation that structures the film, not only inherent in the very nature of found footage and reels but also as a proper stylistic choice. The diegetic narrative is continually disrupted by shifts of time and place, intertitles, poetic inserts, and scenes that break any linear progression. Extradiegetic captions, in white on black and in both Arabic and English, recall silent cinema and divide the film into four uneven parts. The first chapter, *Fī Maṭḥaf al-Ayyām* (“In the Museum of Days”), occupies nearly half of the film’s length and gathers a dense constellation of images and sounds, from bucolic landscapes to camp life and urban devastation.

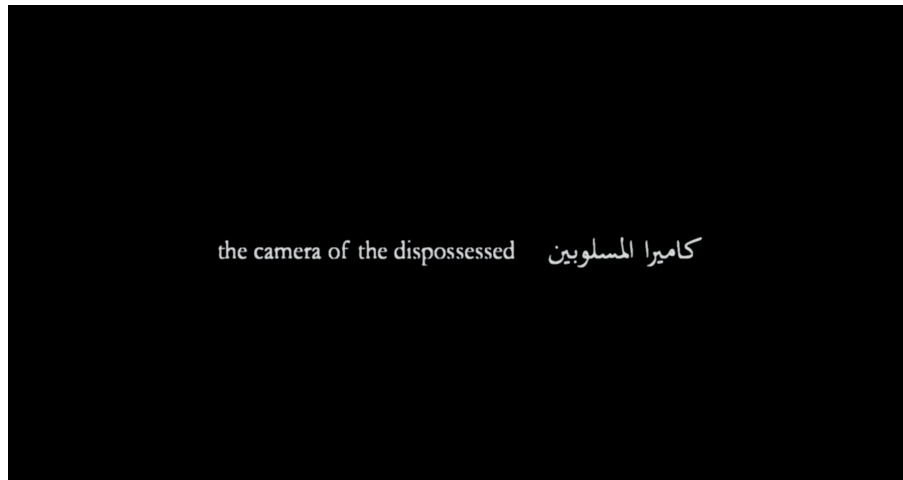


Figure 9 - Still from *A Fidai Film*. Caption of the intertitle “The Camera of the Dispossessed,” which gives its name to the section. Courtesy of Kamal Aljafari Productions

The following sections – *Ten Meters Only*, *The Camera of the Dispossessed*, and *Epilogue* – collectively account for less than an hour, an imbalance that is central to the film’s parafictional aesthetics. Rather than distributing information evenly, Aljafari constructs a structure in which density and scarcity coexist.

Typewritten poetic inserts frequently precede or follow the scenes they describe, generating temporal disjunctions that destabilize progressive chronology. In doing so, the film materializes what Hochberg describes as the «phantasmal power» of the archive (2021:27), that is, its capacity to promise access to the past while simultaneously revealing its own ghosts, absences, and erasures. In this unstable configuration, the right to fabulate emerges as a foundational tool of liberation, freeing hostile archives from the colonial veil that has long confined them to a manipulated past.

The epilogue crystallizes this logic through the device of a fictive phone call legitimizing the whole narrative fabric. It presents a scrolling transcription of the supposed call between Aljafari and an elusive Youssef about the discovery of a lost archive. The text, in Arabic and English, appears in white over a deep red background, a tonal varia-

tion of the film's otherwise dominant fiery red. The conversation oscillates between banality and revelation, without ever disclosing where the archive is or what it contains. This opacity is not a failure to inform but a deliberate stance. Following Glissant, the film claims the right not to make the archive fully legible, refusing the comforts of transparent decoding that accompany colonial epistemologies. The archive remains fugitive: present yet out of reach, mirroring its material inaccessibility.

The few intratextual captions preserved in their original form point back to Aljafari's childhood landscapes – Ramle and Jaffa – often evoked through familiar tropes such as the neon sign of the Alhambra Theatre or Jaffa's typical «sad oranges» (Kanafani 1962). Other captions from archival footage retain their original yellow only when narratively loaded – “IDF and Defense Establishment Archives,” or “UNRWA – A Story That Needs to Be Told” – while most are overwritten in red through the film's signature technique of color-blocking. Traditionally associated with censorship, color-blocking becomes in Aljafari's hands an act of aesthetic insurgency, a key device of sabotage.



Figure 10 and 11 - Stills from *A Fidai Film*. Illustrative use of color-blocking. On the left, the original found footage marked by the yellow writings of colonial archiving; on the right, the manipulated footage employing the iconic use of red to foreground the violence of the occupation. Courtesy of Kamal Aljafari Productions

The fiery red transforms suppression into revelation, engulfing archival stamps and classification codes – the visible signs of colonial re-archiving – in a crimson haze. This chromatic reversal renders the violence of normalization legible, exposing what the archive attempted to bury. Red haunts the screen as both presence and rupture, a trace of injury that refuses closure. It highlights the violence of dispossession without reproducing it, sabotaging its legibility while intensifying an affective disruption. Crucially, Aljafari never obscures Palestinian faces or landscapes; rather, he overlays red on the sun above Jaffa, on children wandering through ruins, on a woman and child

by the shore, and on the bourgeois protagonists of an Israeli melodrama whose seaside dialogue dissolves into a blood-red horizon.



Figure 12 and 13 - Stills from *A Fidai Film*. Exemplary use of fiery red applied to black-and-white found footage. Courtesy of Kamal Aljafari Productions

The sea, often alternating between black-and-white archival footage and digitally tinted crimson, is the film's central motif and Aljafari's enduring obsession. It embodies Palestine's ultimate symbol of displacement, an absent trope of West Bank cinema, and therefore a presence that estranges. Yet it remains a space of a memory that the occupation appropriated but could not alter in its essence, unlike the rural and urban settings of Lebanese camps, Beirut, and Jaffa that appear on screen. If the sea is the horizon of memory, fire becomes its mirror. Appearing most prominently in the brief closing chapter, flame recenters the film's chromatic core and redirects attention to the visual evidence of colonial violence, as the film's diverse repertoire oscillates between scenes of children playing, everyday life in the camps, and stark images of executions, beatings, and devastation.

Dissonant montage further structures the film, operating across both sonic and visual registers, realized through radical formal interventions such as slow motion, looping, circular structures, and abrupt ruptures, in order to produce a haunting soundscape. The sparse diegetic dialogues intertwine with the minimalist audio designed by Attila Faravelli, Aljafari's long-time collaborator, whose work earned the film Best Sound at the 2024 Oslo Film Festival. Drawing on the Palestine Sound Archive alongside studio-created elements, the soundtrack evokes what Mezna Qato and Sadia Shirazi (2020) termed «spectral *ṣumūd*» in their reading of Aljafari's *Port of Memory* (2010): echoing voices, distorted chants, and interrupted melodies conjure presence through absence, enacting a decolonial rupture where the ghostly and the real overlap. The soundscape resists synchrony with the visual track thus refusing to become a transparent vehicle for information. It embodies Shalhoub-Kevorkian's notion of an «occupation of the

senses» (2017), confronting viewers with a world where perception remains unsettled by the memory of violence.



Figure 14 - Still from *A Fidai Film*. The iconic use of red stages the violence of colonial acts of memocide. Courtesy of Kamal Aljafari Productions

This refusal of alignment between sound and image is mirrored by the material condition of the images themselves. Aljafari often works with low-resolution copies, degraded reels, files downloaded from digital platforms, or informally exchanged among researchers, on which he performs materially disruptive and aesthetically dissonant interventions. Rather than treating these conditions as technical limitations or obstacles, he turns them into a stylistic principle. The “poor image” becomes a site of agency, disrupting the aesthetics of high definition that dominate global white visibility – from Hollywood to AI-generated images. Refusing smoothness and clarity, *A Fidai Film* situates itself against a regime in which visibility is calibrated by surveillance technologies and entertainment industries alike. The film counters archival apartheid not only by reclaiming agency over stolen materials, but also by rejecting the norms of visual perfection built atop the very dispossession it exposes.

Ultimately, *A fidai Film* does not aim to reconstruct a complete history from looted fragments. Instead, it foregrounds the conditions that made those fragments vulnerable to looting in the first place and insists that narrating Palestine requires reckoning with gaps, misalignments and spectral presence of what remains unseen. The “camera of the dispossessed” thus names both a position and a practice. It is the camera of those who have been written out of official records and at the same time a way of filming, editing and sounding that breaks the promise of transparency on which colonial archives depend. Palestinian visual and sonic narratives are therefore presented not as consumable stories but through dense and often challenging experimentality, affirming the film’s

fidā'i gesture.

6 - Conclusions

In this paper, I have shown how *From Ground Zero* and *A Fidai Film* articulate two distinct yet deeply intertwined cinematic practices that assert not only the inalienable «permission to narrate» (Said 1984) but also the equally crucial «right to fabulation» (Estefan 2022) against the dominant necrovisual regime. Taken together, these works exemplify what I term archival activism, a constellation of decolonial filmic practices that confront, reclaim, and reimagine the archive within the saturated mediascape of the Gaza genocide.

The close analysis of the two films traced how contemporary Palestinian filmmakers mobilize archival agency through divergent yet complementary strategies. *From Ground Zero* activates what I call “gaze on Gaza”, a synchronous *dispositif* of counter-archiving anchored in the textures of both experienced and imagined life inside the Strip. Its fragmentary structure stages gestures and intimate routines within a tightly aligned sound-image register that reinforces their thematic legibility, while its altered temporalities carve out spaces of speculative futurity that resist the dehumanizing and quantitative logic of necrovisuality. Conversely, *A Fidai Film* advances the *dispositif* of the “camera of the dispossessed”, assembling an insurgent countervisuality from opaque and radically experimental manipulations of looted found footage. Here, fabulation functions as a generative tactic that sabotages a visual order already sabotaged through colonial dispossession. Parafiction emerges not in fictional content but in the film’s combination, repetition, and alteration of archival fragments, producing a deliberately discontinuous narrative whose aesthetically “impoverished” forms become a stylistic commitment rather than a technical limitation. These visual strategies, together with a minimalist and often dissonant soundscape, unsettle the viewer and expose the violence of normalization inherent in colonial dispossession.

Placed in dialogue with the expanding corpus of Palestinian filmmaking released after October 2023, these findings suggest avenues for future research. Combining textual, intertextual, and contextual film analysis with production studies may illuminate how archival activism is shaped by the economic, geopolitical, and biographical conditions of filmmaking across historic Palestine and in the diaspora. A diachronic inquiry could further outline continuities and ruptures in Palestinian cinematic engagements with archives before and after October 2023, revealing whether “Gaze on Gaza” and “the camera of the dispossessed” signal broader tendencies within contemporary archival activism.

In the struggle to sustain Palestinian self-representation amid the rubble of Gaza, these works reveal the archive not as a neutral repository of past truths but as a field of aspiration (Appadurai 2003), a living battlefield where the artistic and the political

converge to negotiate the tension between visibility, resistance, and futurity. In this sense, archival activism becomes a critical toolbox through which individual and collective identities are forged, enacting insurgent creative practices that Palestinian filmmakers critically fabulate to keep the “memory fertile” – echoing the legacy of Michel Khleifi’s seminal film (1981).

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